The woman bowed and left.

“Sugar or milk?” he asked.

Rose would have liked a spoonful of sugar to sweeten the tea, but it was already a privilege to be out of the cold on a stormy night, and she wouldn’t allow herself more. Every comfort might weaken her resolve. That was why he sent her all those gifts. “No, thank you.”

“I’ve just been reading that you and your sister have put in a travel request for Berlin.”

She started, nearly spilling the tea on her dress. She hadn’t expected him to know about Berlin so soon. *Say as little as possible so he can’t catch you in a lie.*

“May I ask, what is the purpose of the Berlin trip?”

She put the cup down, wrapping one hand around the porcelain, giving herself time to think through what else he might know or could find out. Maman had always warned that on the few occasions where a lie was merited, keep it as truthful as possible.

“To visit my cousin.”

“His name?” He lifted the pen from his desk.

“André Simon, my aunt’s son. He works at Tempelhof Airport in Berlin.”

“Ah, yes. The letter.”

She swallowed. She’d memorized every word in André’s letter by heart. He hadn’t said anything about love, just that he wanted her to come to Berlin. She was safe.

“He’s quite sentimental for the summers we played together on the quai in Orléans. I told him I will do my best to visit.” André had been discreet. He must have known the Gestapo would read his letters and wanted to protect her.

“I think my office could easily grant permission for such an outing.” He put the pen down. “However, I would require some cooperation on your part.”

She withdrew her hand from the cup; the tea had now turned cold. “What could—”

“It’s about Herr Capek.” He leaned back in the chair, placing his elbows on the armrests. “He has been tasked to provide minimal medical care.”

“Isn’t that what he does?” She could see from the hardening of his jaw